

Poverty in Premodern Law: Hospitals, Statutes and the Poor (Italy, c. 1560–1750), Course: Law and Humanities (prof. Sara Menzinger). University of Roma Tre - 10 November 2025, Rome, Italy.

Building on Brian Tierney's pioneering *Medieval Poor Law: A Sketch of Canonical Theory and Its Application in England* (Berkeley and Los Angeles, 1959), this lecture asks what law can reveal about how past societies understood and addressed poverty. Focusing on a select body of early modern "statutes" of *hospitalia pauperum*, it examines the context and the reasons for their emergence within early modern legal systems. By placing the legal source, "the statute", before the social definition, "the poor", the lecture aims to recover a thick notion of "poverty" and "care" in Italian early-modern societies. As multifaceted institutions, rooted in Canon Law, hospitals and poorhouses served a wide range of civic and financial functions (from granting local rights to ensuring credit) – that extended far beyond what we would today classify as welfare.